

CITIES, SPACE, POWER ('CSP')

Introduction to Critical Urban Studies

T / Th 12:30 to 1:50pm Winter 2026

Location: Hinds Lab Geo Sci 101

Sociology 20506 / Cross listed in: CEGU, Architectural Studies, 3CT, CHSS, HIPS, History, MAPS, Political Science, Public Policy, and more.

This lecture class is open to students in all programs and at all levels at the University of Chicago. Auditors, guests, and visitors are warmly welcomed into our classroom for any and all lectures. We cannot accommodate non-enrolled students in our weekly class sections.

Instructor: Professor Neil Brenner

Department of Sociology +

Committee on Environment, Geography and Urbanization (CEGU)

University of Chicago

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Office hours

Office hours are held in person in my Sociology office (SSRB 422):

T (2:15 - 4:10 pm)

Th (2:15 - 3:10 or 4:15 pm—varies weekly)

F (2-3 pm)

Sign up link:

<https://calendly.com/neilbrenner/neil-brenner-office-hours>

Other Friday appointment slots may be available during some weeks.

Teaching team (teaching assistants / doctoral candidates):

Nina Olney (Sociology):

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Aaron Stagoff-Belfort (Sociology):

astagoff@uchicago.edu

Section meetings

Required for all enrolled students, every Friday. Specific times to be announced / arranged.

A non-digital classroom environment

To minimize distraction and enhance focus, our classroom environment will be entirely computer-free and phone-free (except for my own slide projections). We expect students to print out all readings rather than to read them on-screen, and to take notes using a non-digital method. This applies to both lectures and section meetings.

Overview of Cities, Space, Power (CSP)

A warm welcome to “Cities, Space, Power”—also known as “CSP.”

CSP provides a broad, deep, multidisciplinary introduction to the critical study of urbanization in the social sciences. The modern capitalist city is by its very nature a multifaceted, politically contested, dynamically changing terrain. To examine the multiple contours and contradictions of modern urban life, the course surveys a broad range of research traditions from across the social sciences, as well as the work of environmental scientists, urban planners and architects. We are interested not only in the material, political-economic, spatial, and infrastructural dimensions of urbanization, but in the construction, contestation, and evolution of knowledge-formations that seek to decipher the rapidly changing, polarized geographies of urban life in the modern world, and the prospects for more socially just, democratic, and environmentally viable cities and forms of urbanization.

To this end, first, we survey various conceptualizations of the city and the urban in the modern world, and we consider how the latter articulate to specific methodological approaches to the study of urban processes, transformations and struggles. Second, we explore the question of how social power is materialized and contested in the spaces of urbanization through the materialization of class exploitation, gendered hierarchization, racial domination, sexual normalization, and oppressive/’othering’ systems of peoplehood in and beyond the city. Following a general consideration of the historical geographies and cyclical rhythms of urbanization under capitalism, the final part of the course investigates several key dimensions of urban restructuring during the last half-century. Key topics include, among others, geoeconomic restructuring and urban crisis; the transformation of urban form; territorial stigmatization and “hyperghettoization”; gentrification and the housing question; the neoliberalization of urban governance; the rise of “platform” urbanism; cities and environmental crises; and struggles over the right to the city.

One of the major agendas of the course is to interrogate critically the various frameworks of conceptualization that have been used to demarcate, focus, and animate urban research and their implications for our evolving understanding of various essential dimensions of cities and urbanization in the modern world. This is an essential basis on which to develop more intellectually adequate, socially relevant, and imaginative approaches to understanding—and shaping—our urbanized planet, its contradictions, its crises, and its potential futures.

Requirements

- *Regular attendance and participation* in all sessions. You may miss one class without penalty (no explanation needed). If you miss three (or more) classes, you will be at risk of an automatic “Fail” for the class. If you are confronting any issues that are impeding your studies this term, please reach out to the teaching team so we can help you find appropriate support.
- *Intensive preparation* for all discussions by reading all assigned texts in advance.
- Meet all *deadlines* for writing assignments, as specified below.
- *7 reaction papers* (RPs). These are 1-paragraph (~300 word) responses to / reflections on the week’s readings. Details to be explained in class.

These are due weekly, starting in Week 1 of the term. These should not be summaries of the readings but critical reflections on issues on the key claims and issues under discussion for the week; they will serve as key reference points in your weekly discussion sections.

There are two weeks in which no RP is due. The first is **February 5**, when your first Analytical Essay (AE) is due (see below). The timing of the second “no RP week” is up to each student: *you may skip the RP during one other week of your choosing, no questions asked*; please simply inform your TA via email.

- *Two analytical essays* (AEs). These are ~5 pages each (approximately 2500 words). Deadlines are **February 5** and **March 11**. For each AE, we will provide a list of question prompts, from which you will select a topic. The specifics of each assignment will be explained in class, one week in advance of the due date.
- *Extra credit work* (EC). Extra credit opportunities will be announced during the course of the term. Generally, EC credit involves attending events related to urban social science and contemporary urban transformations in Chicago and beyond.

To receive extra credit, please submit a brief response paper (much like the RP) reflecting on the event and its relation to any reading(s) or issue(s) that have been discussed in class. Details on submission procedures to be announced in class.

Grading

- 25% Attendance and participation
- 25% Reaction papers (RPs)
- 25% Analytical essay #1 (AE1)
- 25% Analytical essay #2 (AE2)
- The impact of EC work on your final grade depends on the excellence and amount that is submitted. This may result in a “boost” to your final grade by up to ½ a grade (e.g., from B to B+, from B+ to A-, or from A- to A).

Academic Honesty and use of Artificial Intelligence

Plagiarism will result in a failing grade for the assignment and possibly for the course, as well as a referral to the Dean of Students. Plagiarism is the accidental or intentional copying of phrases or sentences without proper citation to the author or source. This may include published texts, material found on the internet or the work of students and colleagues.

Be sure to document the exact sources of everything you write down in your notes; use quotation marks if you are quoting anything, be it a phrase or a sentence. These are essential habits to “lock in” now to avoid making any future mistakes in this regard, whether as students or in future professional / academic contexts.

Please note: *the use of chatbots or any other AI-based writing tools is not permitted for any part of any of the writing assignments for this class.* Using such tools defeats the purpose of our work here—developing your capacity to read, think, and write autonomously. This takes hard work and practice; there is simply no short cut. So let's do the work rather than relying on machines and algorithms to do it for us.

NOTE: Many, if not all, assignments for this course, will be written by hand, using notebooks provided by the teaching team. Details to be announced.

SCHEDULE OF ASSIGNMENTS AND READINGS

The course is divided into three main parts, each of which consists in five topics / lectures followed by an “intermezzo” session in which we discuss the issues raised in the preceding unit. Weekly (required) discussion sections take place every Friday, in which you will discuss in greater detail the issues raised in the preceding week’s readings and lectures, as well as upcoming writing assignments.

NOTE: there may be updates / additions to the syllabus during the course of the term.

Day	Date	Topic and reading	Assignment
T	1/6	Introduction and overview of the course • David Harvey, “The right to the city,” <i>International Journal of Urban and Regional Research</i>, 27, 4, 2003, 939-941. • Brandi T. Summers, “What Black America knows about Quarantine,” <i>New York Times</i>, 15 May 2020. • Zheng Xiaoqiong, “The makers of modern China,” <i>equator</i>, 10.12.2025 (translated by Eleanor Goodman). • Mark Williams, “Cities will leave a clear and globally widespread geological record of their impact that will persist for millions of years,” Interview with Lucas Tirphine, École Urbaine de Lyon, November 26, 2020. • United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN-DESA), <i>World Urbanization Prospects, 2018: Highlights</i>. New York: United Nations, 2019 (skim). • United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN-DESA), <i>The World’s Cities in 2025: Data Booklet</i>. New York: United Nations, 2025 (skim).	Please be sure to read these essays after the first class meeting.

PART 1

CONTOURS OF THE URBAN QUESTION IN THE MODERN WORLD

What is the city? What is the urban? What is urbanization? How have these phenomena or processes been conceptualized in the social sciences? How have such conceptualizations been articulated to specific sites and scales of research, and to specific methods of investigation?

Th	1/8	The ‘metropolitan’ experience - Georg Simmel, “The metropolis and mental life,” in <i>On Individuality and Social Forms</i>, edited by Donald Levin. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1971 [1903], 324-339. - Edgar Allan Poe, “The man of the crowd,” in <i>The Portable Edgar Allan Poe</i>, edited by J. Gerald Kennedy. New York: Penguin, 2006 [1840], 229-237. - Re-read: Zheng Xiaoqiong, “The makers of modern China,” <i>equator</i>, 10.12.2025 (translated by Eleanor Goodman).	RP 1
T	1/13	The production of urban ‘ways of life’ Louis Wirth, “Urbanism as a way of life,” <i>American Journal of Sociology</i>, 44, 1 (1938): 1-24.	
Th	1/15	Urbanization and the spatial dynamics of capital - David Harvey, “Cities or urbanization?,” <i>CITY</i> 1, 1-2 (1996): 38-61. Optional: - David Harvey, “Money, time, space, and the city,” <i>The Urban Experience</i>. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins UP, 1989, 165-199.	RP2

T	1/20	Urbanization and the transformation of the earth • Lewis Mumford, “The natural history of urbanization,” in William T. Thomas ed., <i>Man’s Role in the Changing Face of the Earth</i>. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1956, 382-400. • Abel Wolman, “The metabolism of cities,” <i>Scientific American</i>, 1965, 179-190. • Christopher Kennedy, John Cuddihy and Joshua Engel-Yan, “The changing metabolism of cities,” <i>Journal of Industrial Ecology</i> 11, 2 (2007): 43-59. • Neil Brenner and Nikos Katsikis, “Operational landscapes: hinterlands of the Capitalocene,” <i>AD/Architectural Design</i> 1 (2020), 22-31.	
Th	1/22	Tracking the spatial imprint of urbanization: between theory and cartography • Urban Theory Lab-GSD, “Visualizing an urbanized planet—materials,” in Neil Brenner ed., <i>Implosions/Explosions: Towards a Study of Planetary Urbanization</i>. Berlin: Jovis, 2014, 460-475. • Jean Gottmann, “Metropolitan systems around the world,” <i>Ekistics</i> 42, 243 (1976): 109-113. • C. A. Doxiadis, “The emerging Great Lakes Megalopolis,” <i>Ekistics</i>, 72, 430-535 (2005 [1968]): 167-188. • John Rennie Short, “The liquid city of megalopolis,” in Gary Bridge and Sophie Watson eds., <i>The New Blackwell Companion to the City</i>. Malden, MA.: Blackwell, 2011, 26-37. • Richard Florida, Tim Gulden and Charlotta Mellander, “The rise of the mega-region,” <i>Cambridge Journal of Regions, Economy and Society</i> 1 (2008): 459-476 • Christopher Bren d’Amour et. al., “Future urban land expansion and implications for global croplands,” <i>PNAS</i>, 114, 34 (2017): 8939-8944.	RP3

		Neil Brenner and Nikos Katsikis, "Is the Mediterranean urban?," in Neil Brenner ed., <i>Implosions/Explosions: Towards a Study of Planetary Urbanization</i>. Berlin: Jovis, 2014, 428-459.	
T	1/27	Intermezzo: discussion on Part 1	
PART 2 URBAN SPACE AND SOCIAL POWER How should we understand the spatial organization of urban life? How does urban space materialize social power relations (of class, gender, 'race', sexuality, and positionality in the world economy)? Under what conditions, and through what processes, might such systems of power, exclusion and domination be contested, destabilized, and superseded through the remaking of urban space?			
Th	1/29	The Chicago School: human ecology and 'urban' ideology - Ernest Burgess, "The growth of the city," in <i>The City</i>. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1925, 47-62. - Robert Park, "Human Ecology," <i>American Journal of Sociology</i>, 41, 1 (1936): 1-15.	RP4 AE1 topics distributed
T	2/3	Capitalist and colonial divisions of urban space - Friedrich Engels, "Dedication," "Preface," "Introduction," "The Industrial Proletariat," "The Great Towns," and "The attitude of the bourgeoisie towards the proletariat," in <i>The Condition of the Working Class in England</i> (Leipzig, 1845)—available on marxists.org - Janet Abu-Lughod, "Tale of Two Cities: The Origins of Modern Cairo," <i>Comparative Studies in Society and History</i>, 7, 4 (1965): 429-457.	

Th	2/5	The ghetto, the 'color line' and urban apartheid W. E. B. Du Bois, <i>The Philadelphia Negro: A Social Study</i> (New York: Oxford University Press, 2007 [1899], Chs. 1-2, 4, 7, 10-12, 15, 18. - St. Clair Drake and Horace Cayton, "The Black Ghetto," in <i>Black Metropolis: A Study of Negro Life in a Northern City</i>. New York: Harper & Row, 1945 [1961], 174-213. - James Baldwin, "Fifth Avenue Uptown: A Letter from Harlem," in <i>Nobody Knows My Name: More Notes of a Native Son</i>. New York: Dial Press, 1961, 56-71. - Prentiss Dantzler, "The urban process under racial capitalism: race, anti-Blackness, and capital accumulation," <i>Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and the City</i>, 2, 2, (2021): 113-134. - Melissa M. Valle, "Revealing the ruse: shifting the narrative of colorblind urbanism," <i>International Journal of Urban and Regional Research</i>, Spotlight essay, 2017: https://www.ijurr.org/spotlight-on/race-justice-and-the-city/revealing-the-ruse-shifting-the-narrative-of-colorblind-urbanism/	AE1 due
T	2/10	Gender, sexuality and urban space - Janet Wolff, "The invisible <i>flâneuse</i>: women and the literature of modernity," <i>Theory, Culture and Society</i>, 2, 3 (1985): 37-46. - Dolores Hayden, "What would a non-sexist city be like? Speculations on housing, urban design and human work," <i>Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society</i> 5, 3 (1980): S170-S187. - Yvonne P. Doderer, "LGBTQs in the city, queering urban space," <i>International Journal of Urban and Regional Research</i> 35, 2 (2011): 431-436. - Kian Goh, "Safe cities and queer spaces: the urban politics of radical LGBT activism," <i>Annals of the Association of American Geographers</i> 108, 3/4 (2018): 463-477.	

Th	2/12	Urban environmental injustice, eco-apartheid and social murder • Neil Smith, “There’s no such thing as a natural disaster,” <i>Items from the Social Sciences</i>, June 11, 2006. • Eric Klinenberg, “Dying alone: the social production of urban isolation,” <i>Ethnography</i> 2, 4 (2001): 501-531. • Ashley Dawson, “Capital sinks” and “Climate apartheid,” in <i>Extreme Cities: The Peril and Promise of Urban Life in the Age of Climate Change</i>. New York: Verso, 2017. • Nikhil Anand, “Water crisis,” <i>International Journal of Urban and Regional Research</i>, Spotlight essay, 2018. Open access at: https://www.ijurr.org/spotlight-on/parched-cities-parched-citizens/water-crisis/ • Daniel Aldana Cohen, “Water crisis and eco-apartheid in São Paulo,” <i>International Journal of Urban and Regional Research</i>, Spotlight essay, 2018. Open access at: https://www.ijurr.org/spotlight-on/parched-cities-parched-citizens/water-crisis-and-eco-apartheid-in-sao-paulo-beyond-naive-optimism-about-climate-linked-disasters/ • Lindsey Dillon and Julie Sze, “Police power and particulate matters: environmental justice and the spatialities of in/securities in US cities,” <i>English Language Notes</i> 54, 2 (2016): 13-23. • Josh Seim, “Covid-19 as social murder,” <i>Spectre</i>, 22 April 2020: https://spectrejournal.com/covid-19-as-social-murder/	RP5
T	2/17	Intermezzo: discussion on Part 2	

PART THREE

URBANIZATION AND THE HISTORICAL GEOGRAPHIES OF CREATIVE DESTRUCTION

How and why do cities change? How should we understand the recurrent crises of urbanization under capitalism? What are the consequences of such crises for the built environment, social life, politics and environmental conditions? What kinds of new urban spaces, and new forms of urbanization, are emerging under 21st century conditions?

Th	2/19	Rhythms of urban restructuring and crisis formation - David Gordon, "Capitalist development and the history of American cities," in William Tabb and Larry Sawyers eds., <i>Marxism and the Metropolis</i>. New York: Oxford University Press, 1984, 25-63. - David Harvey, "The urbanization of capital," in <i>The Urban Experience</i>. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1989, 17-58. - Edward W. Soja, "Regional urbanization and the end of the metropolis era," in Gary Bridge and Sophie Watson eds., <i>The New Blackwell Companion to the City</i>. Malden, MA.: Blackwell, 2011, 679-689.	RP6
T	2/24	New geographies of global urbanization—various perspectives - Re-read (from Part One): United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN-DESA), <i>World Urbanization Prospects—2018 Highlights</i>. New York, United Nations, 2019 (skim). - Re-read: United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN-DESA), <i>The World's Cities in 2025: Data Booklet</i>. New York: United Nations, 2025 (skim). - Saskia Sassen, "Locating cities on global circuits," <i>Environment and Urbanization</i> 14, 1 (2002): 13-30. - Mike Davis, "Planet of slums: urban involution and the informal proletariat," <i>New Left Review</i> 26, March/April (2004), 5-34.	

		• Re-read (from Part One): Zheng Xiaoqiong, "The makers of modern China," <i>equator</i>, 10.12.2025 (translated by Eleanor Goodman). • Neil Brenner, "Urban revolution?," in <i>Critique of Urbanization</i>. Basel: Birkhäuser Verlag, 2016, 192-211. • Stephanie Wakefield, "Critical urban theory in the Anthropocene," <i>Urban Studies</i>, 59, 5 (2021): 917-936. • Fulong Wu, "Emerging Chinese cities: implications for global urban studies," <i>The Professional Geographer</i> 68, 2 (2016): 338-348.	
Th	2/26	New spatial divisions: the hyperghetto and 'advanced' marginality • Loïc Wacquant, "Territorial stigmatization in the age of advanced marginality," <i>Thesis Eleven</i> 91, November (2007): 66-77. • Teresa Caldeira, "Fortified Enclaves: The New Urban Segregation," <i>Public Culture</i> 8 (1996): 303-328. • Javier Auyero, "'This Is a lot Like the Bronx, Isn't It?' Lived Experiences of Marginality in an Argentine Slum," <i>International Journal of Urban and Regional Research</i> 23, 1 (1999): 45-69. • Marco Garrido, "Reconceptualizing segregation from the global South," <i>City & Community</i>, May 2020.	RP7
T	3/3	Gentrification, displacement and uneven development • Neil Smith, "Towards a theory of gentrification: A back to the city movement by capital, not people," <i>Journal of the American Planning Association</i> 45, 4 (1979): 538-548. • Neil Smith, "New globalism, new urbanism: gentrification as a global urban strategy," <i>Antipode</i> 34, 3 (2002): 427-450. • Ernesto López-Morales, Hyun Bang Shin and Loretta Lees, "Latin American Gentrifications," <i>Urban Geography</i> 37, 8 (2016): 1091-1108.	

		• Melissa M. Valle, "Globalizing the sociology of gentrification," <i>City & Community</i>, May 2020: https://doi.org/10.1111/cico.12507	
Th	3/5	Environmental emergencies and the politics of urban 'sustainability' • Mike Davis, "Who will build the ark?" <i>New Left Review</i> 61, Jan-Feb (2010): 29-46. • Peter Droege, "One hundred tons of Armageddon: cities combat carbon," in Gary Bridge and Sophie Watson eds., <i>The New Blackwell Companion to the City</i>. Malden, Mass.: Blackwell, 2011, 108-120. • David Owen, "More like Manhattan," <i>Green Metropolis</i>. New York: Riverhead, 2009, Ch. 1 • Daniel Aldana Cohen, "Seize the Hamptons," <i>Jacobin</i> 10 (2014): https://www.jacobinmag.com/2014/10/seize-the-hamptons/ • David Wachsmuth, Daniel Aldana Cohen and Hillary Angelo, "Expand the frontiers of urban sustainability," <i>Nature</i> 25 August 2016, 391-393.	RP8 AE2 topics provided (due 3/11)